Smudge

By Rachel Axler

(COLBY and NICHOLAS are in a strange, sterile hospital room. COLBY is pregnant. They stare at a small slide, motionless.) (Long pause)

COLBY: Maybe it's upside-down.

NICHOLAS: Breach? *(COLBY looks at him.)* I think they float around a lot, so you don't have to worry. I mean, how it's positioned right now probably doesn't matter with regard to -

COLBY: I meant the picture.

NICHOLAS: . . . Right. *(NICHOLAS turns the picture around. They stare with renewed interest.) (Pause.)*

COLBY: No. Right?

NICHOLAS: Right. Yeah. No. It's all . . . grainy.

COLBY: Like a blob.

NICHOLAS: Like it's hiding.

COLBY: Awww . . . it's our first time not seeing our baby together. *(They smile at each other)* Well. It's okay. I mean . . . frustrating. We could do it again. Come back in a couple of weeks.

NICHOLAS: You know. I think it *is* okav. We can surprised.

COLBY: Yeah. Mary if she's plain. Cassandra if she's beautiful.

NICHOLAS: Jake if she's a boy,

COLBY: She's a girl. She's definitely a girl. . . . Nick? I had another one last night.

NICHOIAS: Nightmare?

COLBY: She came out inside-out. Two-dimensional. I got papercuts. . . . *Cassandra.* Cassandra. Unless she's a Mary . . . Or a Jake. *(Pause. They take one last look at the slide.)* Maybe it's just . . . smudged.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Most couples look at the sonogram of their impending baby to see whether it's a boy or a girl.*
ACTRESS: *But when Colby and her husband, Nick, scrutinize the picture of the life in her womb for an answer to the "what is it?" question, they are appalled to realize that they mean IT.*
ACTOR: *Literally.*
TOGETHER: *Smudge by Rachel Axler*

(COLBY in a hospital gown. No longer pregnant. She talks lo the audience.)

COLBY: I think I thought it would be bigger. They hand it to Nick immediately, like they can't wait to get rid of it. Like they think I'd hurt it. It's sort of purplish-grey. And it's skinny, so skinny, except for its head, which is immeasurably huge. The nurses won't look me in the eye. They whisper. The doctor comes in, three brisk strides. Tells us they need it back now. They wash it, dry it off. It's a quiet thing. It whispers. I count one head. Shading for a torso. A sort of nub. A sort of spike. A point, like a tail, or like a talon, near the bottom. Sort of like a jellyfish. Sort of like something that's been erased. The doctor rushes it away and puts it under a glass. This is how I see it. Under glass, covered in tubes and tape. The eye has opened. Coils of fur grow on it, in odd places. And mv husband loves it.

NICHOLAS. Cassandra. Little Cassie. Cassio. One pretty babe.

COLBY. The open eye is beautiful. Luminous, almost. Blue-green. It's a disturbing trick of nature, to put that one beautiful eye into that smudge. The eye is intelligent. Nicholas shows it a Barney puppet, and it blinks.

NICHOLAS. There's a girl. There's a girl. Who's the prettiest of all?

COLBY: There's a feeding tube and a breathing tube and several other tubes performing mysterious, important functions. They should have handed it to me. That first moment - that instant did it. It bonded with Nick. It doesn't like me. There's jealousy in its eye as it counts my hands, finds itself lacking. It wants my fingers.

It dares me to unleash it - lift the glass and tear off the tubes, so it can fly at me and claim my fingers as its own.

NICHOLAS: Cassandra. Little Cassie. Cassie watches me with one eye closed, one all-seeing. **Her** Caribbean Sea-colored eye. I want to touch her, my thumb on her cheek, to smooth her skin, stretched so tightly . . .

COLBY: . . . They're letting us take it home soon. No. I didn't say it was a baby. A baby is something you hold in your arms. That you can wrap in a blanket and show your family and take pictures of and . . . And you're supposed to want to take care of it. I mean, biologically, that's why babies are cute. Because they're helpless little spit-up machines, but somehow nature tricks you into recognizing something of yourself in them. And that's supposed to be your compensation, at least 'til they grow up and become interesting. You know? In the beginning, you don't get much, but you at least get something you can actually touch. Something that . . . responds.

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *Imagine being in your early 20s – blissfully expecting your first child. No signs throughout the pregnancy of any complications, any abnormalities.*
ACTRESS: *Now imagine meeting your severely disabled daughter for the first time, knowing that you will be taking her home soon and that your life will be forever changed . . .*
ACTOR: *not with the joy of a new-born baby girl, but with monitors, tubes, and a living being who isn't quite human.*
ACTRESS: *How do parents cope under these circumstances?*
ACTOR: *Not the politically correct, fairy-tale version, but realistically? . . .*
ACTRESS: *At home with Nicholas, Colby and Cassandra (aka Smudge)*

(NICHOLAS dangles a stuffed toy carrot over the carriage)

NICHOLAS: Okay, Cass! Do we know what time it is? *(like a studio audience)* "Eye exercise time!" That's right! Left. And right. And left. And right – switch it up now! - Right. And left. And right. And – okay, wrong, Cass, but you'll get it eventually. You will get it. Guess that's enough eye work for today. Which means it's tiiiiime tooooo . . catch it! Catch it! Catch it! *(Colby enters. She watches Nick)* Catch it!

Catch . . . . it! Catch the carrot? Catch? Catch?

COLBY: You're tormenting it. *(Nick turns quickly, caught)*

NICHOLAS: Cassie likes it. It's her favorite game.

COLBY: *(with "air quotes")* Did "she" tell you that?

NICHOLAS: *("air quotes")* Don't say "she."

COLBY: *("air quotes")* You told me to say "she."

NICHOLAS: *(NO "air quotes")* No, I told you to say she.

COLBY: That carrot is creepy. Dangling that thing over that . . . other thing. Perverse. Then again, maybe there's some sort of kinship there. Neither one is anatomically correct.

NICHOLAS: Honestly? I'd be much more inclined to listen to your parenting tips if I ever saw you doing any parenting . . . What do you do here? When I'm at work?

COLBY: Sit. Weep. Count the hours.

NICHOLAS: Seriously

COLBY: What do you want me to tell you?

NICHOLAS: I want you to tell me what you do. Do you play games? Do you do exercises Are you even home? Who's watching our daughter?

COLBY: I'm always watching the monitor, Nick. If something goes wrong, trust me -

NICHOLAS: Not the monitor. Cassie. Are you watching Cassie? Do you interact with her? You don't look at her. I've never seen you look at her. Not once since she's come home. I don't even think you know what she looks like.

COLBY: I know what she looks like.

NICHOLAS: No. you don't. You were so worried about my takin on extra work. But I sit at the office and I can't concentrate, because I'm too busy worrying about whether you're taking care of her.

COLBY: You know what - I'm not. I'm not. I'm listening to the "beep-beep-beep" that's so ingrained in my brain right n ow – SO ingrained – I honestly think I'd keep

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hearing it if it stopped. And I'd just keep sitting here, listening to a phantom monitor while she died. And you know what else? That would be fine with me. *(Pause)*

NICHOLAS: Okay, that's it. I am DEAD SERIOUS. Colby, You're going to pick up that carrot. And you're going to come over here and dangle that carrot over the carriage. And you are going to **SMILE**. And you are going to **CARE**. And you're going to tell your daughter a happy story about that carrot and while you tell that happy carrot story **YOU ARE GOING TO LOOK AT YOUR DAUGHTER**. *(Beat. Then, composed)* I'll be in the bedroom. *(Nicholas exits. Colby approaches the carriage and peeks in. As she does the monitor begins frantically beeping – it's furious, angry. Cassie backs away and the beeping returns to normal. Note – The actor playing Nicholas can provide this sound effect from "off stage") (Colby sits in a corner, as far as possible from the carriage, which is emitting weird, angry beeps)*

COLBY: I'm not listening to you. *(Angry beeps)* La la la la la la la *(mimicking beeps)* I'm not paying attention to you. *(Angry beeps)* . . . Okay, I guess I'm talking to you. But t hat's it. *(Particularly angry beeps)* Nick's going to find out, you know. You can't hid your nature from a parent for long. He'll figure it out. Oh – I think I hear him coming, right now! You going to ball "normal" for him? *(the beeps subside to a gentle rhythm again)* Figured. *(Nicolas enters)*

NICHOLAS: Okay, girls – I'm off. Have fun. Don't do anything I wouldn't do.

COLBY: Ha. *(Colby smiles wanly) (Nicholas exits) (Angry beeps begin again)* Why don't you put on your show for Nick? Saving it for me? Should I be flattered? *(angry beeping)* By the way, you're not getting that carrot back. I made you something better. No no, please – don't get up. I'll bring it over there, to you. *(Colby takes out a crude, creepy ragdoll It's been cobbled together from the useless arms and legs of Cassie's onesies It's kind of grotesque)* Here it is. You like it? *(She dangles it over the carriage)* I call him Mister Limbs. Mister Limbs has everything you

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don't. Plus? *(Colby squeezes Mister Limbs)* Water absorbent. Maybe I could use you to mop something up. Or maybe you'd just Smudge all over the floor *(Angry beeps).* The fact is – and brace yourself, Smudge, 'cause this is reality – Nothing looks like you. Nothing in nature. Nothing is crated like you. Not purposely *(Angry beeping)* That's it? That's your response? Been there, Smudge. What else have you got? *(angry beeping)* You need new material. Yeah, I know you're terrifying. But I can be pretty scary, too. Know what I've got, Smudge? *(Colby holds up a tiny pair of scissors)* I've got these. *(beeps)* And I could do it. Just one snip. Tiny triangle in the tubing. Like the first peck through the shell of an egg. SNIP. Freedom *(frantic beeping*). I want to scare you. I want to see horror in your little half-face. I want you to scream. I want to hear what your voice sounds like. I want to pinch you until I prove there's blood in there. I want to poke you with a stick. *(the beeps quicken until they're one steady scream)* Move. MOVE, dammit. Blink. Blink! SHOW ME YOU'RE ALIVE. *(Everything stops, and Colby draws in a sharp breath, staring into the crib.)* Nicholas . . . Nicholas . . . *(Colby runs to the phone. Dials)* She smiled.

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *And a connection, however tenuous it may be is made . . . Hope is renewed . . . .*

NICHOLAS: Smile! Smile for the carrot, Cass! Smile! It's smiling at you! Your heart beats. Your brain functions, and I'm talking to you and I'm not crazy. Which means you're alive. Living is empirical. It's scientific. Check off a box – alive or dead? Yes or no. Zero or one. Living can't be qualified. You're a one. I'm sure you're a one. *(Freezes in place)*

COLBY: *(to the carriage)* I don't love you. I hope that's okay. I know you're not too fond of me either. Nick told me I'm "not open to our bond." The thing is,

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you're kind of hard to bond with. *(breathes in time with the monitor)*

NICHOLAS: *(unfreezing)* You were breathing . . . in rhythm. With the *(he indicates the monitor)*

COLBY: I was? *(He nods)* . . . . Oh. *(Pause)* Is that bad? *(pause)*

NICHOLAS: *(looking into the carriage again)* Cassandra rests on one swollen check. Her skin sags where it has given up. Her eye continues to watch me, always, saying, "I am yours, and you must love me." I look back into the gree-blue sea that refuses to change, and I respond: Now reachfor the carrot. Just reach for it. Look at it. Blink at it. Please. Gow, Cassie. Stretch. Why won't you look at me? Move! Grow! Change! Change, you little monster.

COLBY: Nick. We could try again. Couldn't we? Try again? I want a child.

NICHOLAS: We have a child.

COLBY: Where? *(Nicholas looks toward the crib. He makes a decision. He makes a cradle with his arms)*

NICHOLAS: Right here.

COLBY: . . . Tell me about her.

NICHOLAS: She smells like graham crackers.

COLBY: How many arms does she have?

NICHOLAS: Two.

COLBY: How many legs?

NICHOLAS: Two

COLBY: Does she have a body?

NICHOLAS: And two eyes. A face. A perfect, tiny face.

COLBY: What's she doing now?

NICHOLAS: She's reaching out . . . grabbing your hand. Wrapping her stubby little fingers around your thumb.

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COLBY: Veins spider-webbing through her skin. The tiniest nails you've ever seen. She has eyebrows. Eyelashes. Gums, but eventually teeth.

NICHOLAS: She's saying her first word. It's "Mamma."

COLBY: She's taking her first step.

NICHOLAS: She's leaving us – waving goodbye from the school bus.

COLBY: It's just her first day of kindergarten.

NICHOLAS: Her first day of high school.

COLBY: Her first day of college.

NICHOLAS: She rows crew.

COLBY: Varsity soccer.

NICHOLAS: MVP

COLBY: Pre-med!

NICHOLAS: She's an artist.

COLBY: She gets engaged!

NICHOLAS: She gets married!

COLBY: She's having a ba – (by) *(Everything goes silent, the word hanging unfinished in the air). (NICHOLAS FREEZES) (Colby speaks to audience as she looks into the carriage at her baby)* You know what my primary fear was, whenever I used to think about a child? I was scared that there'd be something unappealing about her. To other kids. Something weird or socially awkward, that would get her teased. Or that she'd . . . Jesus, that maybe she'd be walking to school one day and get hurt. Snatched. Something out of my control.

NICHOLAS: *(unfreezes and joins Colby at the carriage)* You know it's going to be hard. You know that, right?

COLBY: I know . . . I really know. *(Colby reaches into the carriage to touch her baby for the first time. Unsure of herself, like a new mother)*

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